

Things We Can Not Return To

By Lucia Lorenz

The sky slowly bloomed into a strawberry hue as a man stumbled upon a willow tree, admiring how the dangling twigs and leaves brushed against one another in the breeze. He gently parted the curtain of branches and walked to the trunk. He slid down the damp bark until he could feel the cold soil and roots seep underneath.

The man finally closed his eyes, as if his body had been yearning all day. He listened to the flutes of cicadas and the hum of crickets, who came out to say good morning in the night.

A gust of wind filled his lungs, carrying the sweetest, almost candy-like scent through his nose. That wind, those smells, they hypnotized him, drawing him back to when his small legs and blistered toes carried him through the weeds and wildflowers of the meadow. Reminding him of the bumblebees that floated in the air, tranquilly bobbing in the summer breeze. How he used to move his small fingers and pale hands with them, as if they were calling him to dance to their buzzing rhythm.

He remembered how that soft melodic voice used to call for him.

“Darling! It is time to come inside.”

When he turned toward the voice, he found the wooden windmill towering above him. Each time he saw its molding foundation, he swore it had sunk a little deeper into the soil. Even nature wanted it gone, wanted it swallowed whole into the earth’s flaming core. Whenever he used to step into the windmill, he convinced himself he could smell fruit that had once been ripe now rotting for years. The scent stung his nose and brought tears to his hazel eyes. While the doors that barely clung to their hinges welcomed the maggots and flies that fed upon the splintering wood.

But in the frame of the door stood a golden light. Its radiance stretched all the way into the meadow, warming his skin where he stood. Within it lingered the silhouette of a figure, glowing hotter than the sun itself. Looking upon them, the knot in his chest loosened. The warmth filled his lungs and wrapped around him. He swore he could see his dreams within that yellow haze and hear blissful, genuine laughter spilling from light. In its warmth, the man watched life and vivid flowers bud and bloom.

“Come on, Darling.”

He heard them again and watched a wrinkled hand stretch out toward him. Beckoning him forward.

So he ran.

His toes flung dirt with each step, his scrawny arms pumping back and forth, back and forth, as though they could carry him faster. The golden figure began to flicker and dim, as if the windmill itself threatened to consume it.

He never took his eyes off them, tearing through the tall grass without care for the insects and small creatures crushed beneath his feet. Each pounding step sent a shock rattling up his legs. The light grew dimmer and dimmer.

He wanted to shout, to beg them to wait, to stay.

But they did not.

The light went out, and the door closed.

The man finally woke.

Slowly opening his eyes, he watched the morning star seep in between the branches. Listening to the soft baby birds wake from their slumber, he realized cool tears threatened his eyes. That windmill was nothing more than a nightmare when he was a child. Even so, he yearned for nothing more than to return to it, to that doorway, to that impossible light.